AETHER NETWORKS

Global Telecommunications Infrastructure

REQUEST FOR PROPOSAL

Next-Generation 5G BSS/OSS Transformation and Real-Time Monetization Platform

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- Negotiate with one or more vendors simultaneously;
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NOTE: *The submission of a proposal in response to this RFP does not entitle any vendor to reimbursement of costs incurred in the preparation of said proposal. All proposal preparation costs are borne exclusively by the responding vendor.*

SECTION 1 Executive Summary and Background

1. Executive Summary and Background

1.1 About Aether Networks

Aether Networks S.A. is a leading pan-European telecommunications operator headquartered in Amsterdam, Netherlands, with licensed network operations across eleven (11) European Union Member States. Aether Networks serves a current base of 45 million active subscribers across Consumer (B2C), Small and Medium Enterprise (SME), and Large Enterprise (B2B) market segments. The company operates a fully licensed 5G New Radio (NR) spectrum portfolio across 700 MHz, 3.5 GHz, and 26 GHz bands and has committed to achieving nationwide 5G Standalone (SA) coverage in its top four markets by Q4 2026.

Aether Networks' consolidated annual revenue exceeds EUR 8.2 billion, with a digital services and advanced connectivity (5G, IoT, and private network) revenue mix of 23%, targeted to grow to 40% by fiscal year 2028. The Group employs approximately 34,000 personnel across its operating footprint and serves over 2.4 million Business customers, including critical national infrastructure operators, financial services institutions, and public sector entities.

1.2 Current Legacy Infrastructure and Business Drivers

Aether Networks currently operates a heterogeneous, multi-vendor BSS/OSS landscape that has evolved organically over a period exceeding eighteen (18) years through acquisitions, market entries, and incremental platform upgrades. The incumbent charging and billing infrastructure comprises a combination of Amdocs Billing (v12.x), a legacy Comverse SMART convergent charging environment, and a proprietary mediation layer operating on end-of-life hardware. This environment presents critical and unacceptable constraints for Aether Networks' 5G SA commercial strategy, specifically:

- Absence of native 3GPP Release 17 Nchf interface support, precluding direct integration with the deployed 5G SA core (Ericsson Cloud Packet Core).
- Monolithic architecture with a scheduled rating engine incapable of achieving the sub-50ms real-time rating latency mandated for 5G network slicing commercial offers.
- Inability to support per-network-slice charging differentiation, rendering the organization unable to monetize committed 5G SA slice SLAs sold to enterprise customers.
- Total Cost of Ownership (TCO) for the legacy BSS environment exceeds EUR 210 million over a five-year horizon, 67% of which is attributable to sustaining engineering and vendor support for end-of-life components.
- Current product time-to-market (TTM) for a new commercial offer exceeds 14 weeks due to rigid product catalog architecture and manual provisioning workflows.
- Absence of cloud-native deployment capabilities prevents adoption of a DevSecOps model and automated zero-downtime continuous delivery pipelines.

The strategic imperative for this transformation programme is therefore unambiguous. Aether Networks requires the immediate procurement of a Next-Generation, cloud-native, fully converged BSS/OSS platform that will serve as the commercial and operational backbone for its 5G SA services, IoT connectivity offerings, and enterprise slice monetization strategy. The target architecture must be capable of supporting 45 million subscribers at Day 1, with a clear and contractually committed horizontal scaling path to 90 million subscribers without architectural re-platforming.

1.3 Programme Objectives

The primary objectives of this transformation programme, and therefore the primary evaluation criteria for proposals received in response to this RFP, are as follows:

- Deploy a fully converged, 3GPP Release 17-compliant Converged Charging System (CCS) with a real-time rating latency of under 50ms at p99 under peak load conditions.
- Achieve complete decommissioning of all legacy Amdocs and Comverse BSS components within 24 months of programme go-live.
- Reduce commercial offer time-to-market from 14 weeks to under 5 business days through a next-generation Product Catalog and automated provisioning pipeline.
- Enable per-network-slice real-time monetization for a minimum of 1,000 enterprise 5G SA slice customers within 18 months of CCS go-live.
- Achieve a programme-level TCO reduction of a minimum 35% versus the incumbent environment over a five-year period.

VENDOR INSTRUCTION: Responses to the Executive Summary section MUST be provided in a strict three-paragraph format detailing: 1. Vendor Overview, 2. Financial Stability, and 3. Relevancy to Aether Networks. Responses not adhering to this format will be disqualified from further evaluation.

2. Scope of Work

2.1 Architectural Philosophy and Guiding Principles

The solution proposed in response to this RFP MUST demonstrably adhere to the following non-negotiable architectural principles. Any proposal that does not fully address each principle with specific technical substantiation will be marked as Non-Compliant for the relevant requirements in Section 3 and will be subject to disqualification.

- Cloud-Native First: All platform components must be delivered as containerized microservices with no monolithic or "lift-and-shift" virtualized application components. Each microservice must be independently deployable, scalable, and upgradeable.
- TM Forum Open API Compliance: The platform must adhere to the TM Forum Open API manifesto. All external and internal service-to-service APIs must conform to published TMF Open API specifications. Proprietary API frameworks are not acceptable as a primary integration mechanism.
- 3GPP Standards Alignment: All charging, provisioning, and network management interfaces must be implemented in strict accordance with the applicable 3GPP Technical Specifications, specifically Releases 16 and 17.
- Zero-Trust Security Architecture: The platform must implement a zero-trust security model across all inter-service communication, API access, and operator management interfaces, with mutual TLS (mTLS) enforced as a minimum standard.
- Open and Interoperable: Aether Networks will not accept vendor lock-in through proprietary data formats, closed integration buses, or non-standard data models. All data must be exportable in open, documented formats.

2.2 Required Platform Modules

The following functional modules are defined as mandatory components within the scope of this RFP. Proposals must address each module explicitly. Vendors may propose the modules as an integrated suite or as individually licensed components, provided that integration between all modules is fully demonstrated and contractually warranted.

- Converged Charging System (CCS): Online Charging System (OCS) and Offline Charging System (OFCS) functions, Policy and Charging Rules Function (PCRF/PCF), Balance Management, and real-time notifications.
- Product Catalog Management (PCM): Master product and offer repository, dynamic pricing engine, promotion management, and TMF620-compliant APIs.
- Billing and Revenue Management (BRM): Invoice generation, payment processing (direct debit, card, electronic), dunning management, revenue recognition, and TMF678-compliant APIs.
- Service and Resource Provisioning (SRP): Automated order management, network resource inventory, service activation, and TMF622/TMF641-compliant APIs.
- Network Integration Layer (NIL): Mediation and collection from 5G SA, 4G LTE, 3G/2G, Wi-Fi, IoT (NB-IoT, LTE-M), and fixed network elements via standard Diameter, RADIUS, and REST/HTTP/2 interfaces.
- Operational Support System (OSS): Network topology management, fault management, performance management, SLA management, and 3GPP TS 28.xxx series-compliant FCAPS functions.

2.3 Vendor Architecture Self-Assessment

Vendors MUST complete the following Vendor Architecture Self-Assessment table for each architectural component of the proposed solution. Incomplete tables will result in the proposal being returned without evaluation. Vendors must add rows for any additional components not listed below that form part of the proposed solution.

Architectural Component	Vendor Proposed Standard	Third-Party Dependencies (Yes/No)	Customization Required (%)
CCS Module	*[Vendor to Fill]*	*[Vendor to Fill]*	*[Vendor to Fill]*
API Gateway	*[Vendor to Fill]*	*[Vendor to Fill]*	*[Vendor to Fill]*
Data Lake Migration	*[Vendor to Fill]*	*[Vendor to Fill]*	*[Vendor to Fill]*
Product Catalog	*[Vendor to Fill]*	*[Vendor to Fill]*	*[Vendor to Fill]*
Billing Engine	*[Vendor to Fill]*	*[Vendor to Fill]*	*[Vendor to Fill]*
Network Provisioning Interface	*[Vendor to Fill]*	*[Vendor to Fill]*	*[Vendor to Fill]*

NOTE: *'Customization Required (%)' is defined as the percentage of the proposed component's functional scope that requires bespoke development or configuration specific to Aether Networks' environment, as opposed to standard out-of-the-box product functionality. Vendors must provide substantiated justification for any entry exceeding 20%.*

3. Technical and Functional Requirements

3.1 Instructions for Completion

This section contains the definitive technical and functional requirements for the Next-Generation 5G BSS/OSS Transformation Platform. Vendors MUST respond to EVERY requirement listed in the table below. Responses must be entered directly into the designated columns of the table. The following response codes are applicable:

- Compliant: The vendor's standard, generally available product fully satisfies the stated requirement without bespoke development, workarounds, or future roadmap commitments.
- Partially Compliant: The vendor's product partially satisfies the stated requirement. The 'Vendor Remarks / Evidence' column MUST contain a specific description of the gap, the proposed resolution, and the estimated effort and timeline to achieve full compliance.
- Non-Compliant: The vendor's product does not satisfy the stated requirement. The 'Vendor Remarks / Evidence' column MUST contain an explanation. Proposals with more than three (3) Non-Compliant responses to Mandatory requirements will be disqualified.

VENDOR INSTRUCTION: Do NOT alter, re-number, or re-sequence the Requirement IDs. Do NOT modify the column structure of the table. Responses must be entered exclusively in the 'Vendor Response' and 'Vendor Remarks / Evidence' columns. Any modification to the table structure will render the proposal non-evaluable.

3.2 Technical and Functional Requirements Matrix

Req. ID	Category	Description	Priority	Vendor Response	Vendor Remarks / Evidence
TR-001	Charging & Rating	The Converged Charging System (CCS) MUST support online charging with end-to-end rating latency of less than 50 milliseconds (p99) under peak load conditions (1M+ TPS).	**Mandatory**	*[Vendor to Fill]*	*[Vendor to Fill]*
TR-002	Standards Compliance	The BSS/OSS platform MUST be fully compliant with 3GPP Release 17 specifications, including support for the Nchf (Charging Function) and CHF (Charging Function) reference points for 5G SA core integration.	**Mandatory**	*[Vendor to Fill]*	*[Vendor to Fill]*
TR-003	API Compliance	All northbound and southbound interfaces MUST expose TM Forum Open API (TMF) compliant REST APIs, covering a minimum of TMF620 (Product Catalog), TMF622 (Product Ordering), TMF635 (Usage Consumption), and	**Mandatory**	*[Vendor to Fill]*	*[Vendor to Fill]*

Req. ID	Category	Description	Priority	Vendor Response	Vendor Remarks / Evidence
		TMF678 (Customer Bill Management).			
TR-004	Data Model	The platform data model MUST map to TM Forum Shared Information Data (SID) model Release 22.0 or later. A full SID mapping document MUST be submitted as Appendix C.	**Mandatory**	*[Vendor to Fill]*	*[Vendor to Fill]*
TR-005	Cloud-Native Architecture	All platform components MUST be delivered as cloud-native microservices containerized via OCI-compliant Docker images, orchestrated on Kubernetes (v1.27+) with full Helm chart deployment support.	**Mandatory**	*[Vendor to Fill]*	*[Vendor to Fill]*
TR-006	High Availability	The platform MUST achieve a minimum of 99.999% availability (Five Nines) for all Tier-1 real-time charging components, with automated failover completing within 30 seconds of primary node failure.	**Mandatory**	*[Vendor to Fill]*	*[Vendor to Fill]*
TR-007	Zero-Downtime Deployment	The platform MUST support automated zero-downtime deployments (rolling updates, blue-green, or canary strategies) for all microservices without subscriber-impacting service interruption.	**Mandatory**	*[Vendor to Fill]*	*[Vendor to Fill]*
TR-008	5G Network Slicing	The CCS MUST support per-slice charging policies, enabling differentiated real-time monetization for each network slice (eMBB, URLLC, mMTC) with isolated policy enforcement points.	**Mandatory**	*[Vendor to Fill]*	*[Vendor to Fill]*
TR-009	Convergence	The platform MUST provide fully converged charging for 2G, 3G, 4G, 5G NSA, and 5G SA network technologies within a single unified CCS instance without data duplication.	**Mandatory**	*[Vendor to Fill]*	*[Vendor to Fill]*
TR-010	Scalability	The CCS and Product Catalog MUST horizontally scale to support a minimum of 45 million active subscribers with a growth headroom of 100% (90 million) without architectural re-platforming.	**Mandatory**	*[Vendor to Fill]*	*[Vendor to Fill]*
TR-011	Product Catalog	The Product Catalog MUST support hierarchical product	**Mandatory**	*[Vendor to Fill]*	*[Vendor to Fill]*

Req. ID	Category	Description	Priority	Vendor Response	Vendor Remarks / Evidence
		structures including Bundles, Add-ons, Offers, and Promotions with a minimum catalog depth of 8 levels and a minimum of 500,000 active catalog entities.			
TR-012	Real-Time Notifications	The platform MUST support real-time event-driven notifications via Kafka or equivalent message broker (ISO/IEC 18384 compliant) with guaranteed delivery semantics (at-least-once) and a maximum latency of 100ms.	**Mandatory**	*[Vendor to Fill]*	*[Vendor to Fill]*
TR-013	AI/ML Integration	The platform MUST provide documented API hooks or native integration for external AI/ML model inference engines to enable dynamic pricing and churn prediction use cases.	**Optional**	*[Vendor to Fill]*	*[Vendor to Fill]*
TR-014	Data Lake & Analytics	The solution MUST include a certified integration adapter for ingesting all CDRs, EDRs, and billing events into an external data lake (Snowflake, Databricks, or Apache Iceberg-compatible) in near real-time (<5 minute lag).	**Mandatory**	*[Vendor to Fill]*	*[Vendor to Fill]*
TR-015	Multi-Currency & Multi-Language	The Billing Engine MUST support a minimum of 35 currencies (including ISO 4217 compliance) and 20 display languages for customer-facing documents.	**Mandatory**	*[Vendor to Fill]*	*[Vendor to Fill]*
TR-016	Roaming	The system MUST support inter-operator roaming settlement via standard TAP3 and IOT (Inter-Operator Tariff) processes, with automated reconciliation and dispute flagging.	**Mandatory**	*[Vendor to Fill]*	*[Vendor to Fill]*
TR-017	Mediation	The platform MUST include an integrated Mediation layer capable of processing a minimum of 500,000 Usage Data Records (UDRs) per second from network probes and network elements.	**Mandatory**	*[Vendor to Fill]*	*[Vendor to Fill]*
TR-018	Revenue Assurance	The platform MUST include built-in revenue assurance controls with automated reconciliation between network usage counters and billed	**Mandatory**	*[Vendor to Fill]*	*[Vendor to Fill]*

Req. ID	Category	Description	Priority	Vendor Response	Vendor Remarks / Evidence
		amounts, with a maximum permissible leakage tolerance of 0.01%.			
TR-019	Self-Service Portal	A fully functional, white-label customer self-service portal (B2C and B2B) MUST be delivered, supporting subscription management, bill payment, usage analytics, and dispute submission.	**Mandatory**	*[Vendor to Fill]*	*[Vendor to Fill]*
TR-020	Legacy Migration Tooling	Vendor MUST provide automated migration tooling for bulk subscriber data migration from the incumbent Amdocs/Comverse legacy environment with a maximum acceptable data loss tolerance of ZERO (0) records.	**Mandatory**	*[Vendor to Fill]*	*[Vendor to Fill]*

4. Operational and OSS Requirements

4.1 Scope

This section defines the mandatory operational, management, and OSS requirements for the proposed platform. These requirements govern the day-to-day operations of the platform in Aether Networks' production environment and will be enforced through contractually binding SLAs. The same response instructions as defined in Section 3.1 apply. Vendors MUST respond to every requirement. Proposals with more than two (2) Non-Compliant responses to Mandatory operational requirements will be disqualified.

VENDOR INSTRUCTION: Vendor responses to Operational Requirements MUST be supported by reference to specific product documentation, version numbers, and available configuration guides. Generic assertions of compliance unsupported by documentation will be downgraded to 'Partially Compliant' by the Aether Networks evaluation team.

4.2 Operational Requirements Matrix

Req. ID	Category	Description	Priority	Vendor Response	Vendor Remarks / Evidence
OP-001	Slice Lifecycle Mgmt	The OSS MUST support fully automated Network Slice lifecycle management (creation, modification, scaling, termination) via 3GPP TS 28.531 compliant NSMF/NSSMF interfaces, with zero manual intervention for steady-state operations.	**Mandatory**	*[Vendor to Fill]*	*[Vendor to Fill]*
OP-002	Fault Management	The platform MUST include a fault management subsystem conforming to TM Forum eTOM L2 processes, with automated root cause analysis (RCA) resolving >90% of Tier-2 and below alarms without human escalation.	**Mandatory**	*[Vendor to Fill]*	*[Vendor to Fill]*
OP-003	SLA Monitoring	The OSS MUST provide real-time SLA monitoring dashboards with configurable threshold alerting, supporting per-slice, per-subscriber, and per-enterprise SLA enforcement with automated breach notification within 60 seconds.	**Mandatory**	*[Vendor to Fill]*	*[Vendor to Fill]*
OP-004	Observability	All platform microservices MUST expose OpenTelemetry-compliant distributed tracing, metrics (Prometheus), and logs	**Mandatory**	*[Vendor to Fill]*	*[Vendor to Fill]*

Req. ID	Category	Description	Priority	Vendor Response	Vendor Remarks / Evidence
		(ELK-compatible), with a pre-built Grafana dashboard library containing a minimum of 50 operational dashboards.			
OP-005	Change Management	The platform MUST support GitOps-based configuration and infrastructure-as-code (IaC) deployment workflows via ArgoCD or Flux, with full audit trails for all configuration changes stored in immutable logs.	**Mandatory**	*[Vendor to Fill]*	*[Vendor to Fill]*
OP-006	Automated Remediation	The system MUST support automated self-healing runbooks (using Ansible or equivalent) capable of executing >80% of standard incident remediation procedures upon alarm trigger without operator intervention.	**Mandatory**	*[Vendor to Fill]*	*[Vendor to Fill]*
OP-007	Capacity Management	The OSS MUST include AI-driven capacity planning modules providing 90-day utilization forecasts for BSS compute, storage, and network resources, with automated scaling recommendations and optional automated execution.	**Optional**	*[Vendor to Fill]*	*[Vendor to Fill]*
OP-008	API-Driven Provisioning	All subscriber provisioning, resource activation, and network configuration operations MUST be executable exclusively via TMF Open API calls, with no dependency on proprietary GUI-based workflows for production operations.	**Mandatory**	*[Vendor to Fill]*	*[Vendor to Fill]*
OP-009	Multi-Cloud Support	The platform MUST be deployable across a minimum of two public cloud providers (AWS, Azure, or GCP) and on-premise bare-metal/VMware environments from a single unified codebase and Helm chart set.	**Mandatory**	*[Vendor to Fill]*	*[Vendor to Fill]*
OP-010	Patch & Upgrade Cadence	Vendor MUST commit to a maximum 72-hour critical security patch SLA and a quarterly feature release cadence, with documented rollback procedures for all upgrade paths tested and certified pre-delivery.	**Mandatory**	*[Vendor to Fill]*	*[Vendor to Fill]*

Req. ID	Category	Description	Priority	Vendor Response	Vendor Remarks / Evidence
OP-011	Disaster Recovery	The solution MUST support an active-active geo-redundant deployment with a Recovery Point Objective (RPO) of 0 seconds and a Recovery Time Objective (RTO) of less than 120 seconds for Tier-1 charging services.	**Mandatory**	*[Vendor to Fill]*	*[Vendor to Fill]*
OP-012	Workforce Management	The OSS MUST include a field workforce management (WFM) module or certified integration adapter for scheduling, dispatching, and tracking field technicians for network and subscriber fault resolution activities.	**Optional**	*[Vendor to Fill]*	*[Vendor to Fill]*

5. Security and Compliance Requirements

5.1 Regulatory and Data Residency Requirements

Aether Networks operates within the jurisdiction of the European Union and is subject to, and fully committed to compliance with, the following regulatory frameworks. All vendors and their proposed solutions MUST demonstrate full compliance with each applicable framework as a condition of bid qualification. Non-compliance with any mandatory regulatory requirement constitutes grounds for immediate disqualification.

- General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR) — Regulation (EU) 2016/679: All subscriber Personally Identifiable Information (PII) processed by the platform, including but not limited to name, address, MSISDN, IMSI, usage data, and billing records, MUST be stored and processed exclusively within European Union data center boundaries. Data transfer to non-EU jurisdictions is strictly prohibited without explicit prior written approval from Aether Networks' Data Protection Officer (DPO). The platform must support the full exercise of GDPR data subject rights (access, rectification, erasure, portability) via automated API-driven workflows within mandated timeframes.
- NIS2 Directive — Directive (EU) 2022/2555: As an essential entity under the NIS2 Directive, Aether Networks requires that all third-party platform components meet NIS2 cybersecurity risk management obligations. Vendors must provide a documented supply chain security posture and vulnerability disclosure program.
- PCI-DSS Level 1: The Billing and payment processing components of the proposed solution MUST be certified to PCI-DSS Level 1 (the highest level), validated by a Qualified Security Assessor (QSA). A current Report on Compliance (RoC) or Attestation of Compliance (AoC) must be provided.
- ISO/IEC 27001:2022: The vendor organization itself, and all subcontractors involved in the delivery and ongoing support of the platform, must hold a current, in-scope ISO/IEC 27001:2022 certification. Current certificates must be attached as Appendix B.
- SOC 2 Type II: Vendors must provide a current SOC 2 Type II report (not older than 12 months) covering the Security, Availability, and Confidentiality Trust Service Criteria for all cloud-hosted components of the proposed solution.

5.2 Platform Security Architecture Requirements

The following security architecture standards are mandatory for all components of the proposed platform:

- Encryption at Rest: All data at rest, including databases, object storage, backup media, and log archives, MUST be encrypted using AES-256 (or AES-256-GCM for authenticated encryption where applicable). Vendor must document the key management architecture, including key rotation policy (maximum 12-month rotation cycle) and Hardware Security Module (HSM) integration.
- Encryption in Transit: All inter-service communication, API calls, and administrative access MUST be encrypted using TLS 1.3 as a minimum standard. TLS 1.2 may be supported for legacy system integration only with explicit written approval from Aether Networks Information Security. TLS 1.0 and 1.1 are explicitly prohibited.
- Identity and Access Management (IAM): The platform MUST integrate with Aether Networks' enterprise identity provider via SAML 2.0 or OIDC, supporting role-based access control (RBAC) with a minimum of fifteen (15) configurable roles and mandatory multi-factor authentication (MFA) for all operator access.
- Secrets Management: All application secrets, API keys, certificates, and cryptographic material MUST be managed via a dedicated secrets management solution (e.g., HashiCorp Vault or equivalent), with no secrets permissible in source code, configuration files, or container images.
- Vulnerability Management: Vendor MUST maintain a documented and auditable vulnerability management program with a maximum 72-hour patch SLA for Critical (CVSS ≥ 9.0) vulnerabilities and a 30-day SLA for High (CVSS 7.0–8.9) vulnerabilities.

- Penetration Testing: The vendor MUST conduct and provide evidence of an independent third-party penetration test against the production-equivalent platform environment, conducted within the 12 months prior to go-live. Aether Networks reserves the right to commission its own independent penetration test at its cost at any point during the contract term.
- Container Security: All container images must be scanned for vulnerabilities using a certified container security scanning tool (e.g., Trivy, Snyk, or Prisma Cloud) prior to deployment. Images with Critical or High CVEs must not be deployed to production environments.
- Network Segmentation: The platform must implement strict network segmentation between Tier-1 charging components, management interfaces, and external-facing APIs, with all cross-segment traffic subject to stateful inspection.

5.3 Security Certification Submission Requirements

VENDOR INSTRUCTION: Attach all security certifications as Appendix B. Do NOT embed certificate images, scanned documents, or certification logos in the main body of the proposal. The main proposal body must contain only a reference table citing the certification name, issuing body, certificate number, and expiry date for each certification claimed. Full certificate documents in PDF format must be provided exclusively in Appendix B.

6. Commercial and Pricing Structure

6.1 Pricing Validity and General Commercial Conditions

All pricing submitted in response to this RFP must adhere to the following mandatory commercial conditions. Proposals that do not fully conform to these conditions will be deemed commercially non-compliant and may be rejected:

- Price Validity: All unit prices, fixed fees, and commercial rates submitted in Section 6.2 must remain firm, fixed, and binding for a minimum period of one hundred and eighty (180) calendar days from the Final Proposal Submission Deadline of 26 September 2025.
- Currency: All pricing must be denominated exclusively in United States Dollars (USD). Prices denominated in alternative currencies will not be accepted.
- Tax Exclusivity: All prices must be stated exclusive of Value Added Tax (VAT), Goods and Services Tax (GST), withholding taxes, and all other applicable taxes and duties. Taxes will be assessed and applied separately in accordance with applicable law.
- Bundled Pricing Prohibition: Vendors may NOT submit bundled lump-sum prices. Each line item in the Pricing Response Table (Section 6.2) must be individually priced to the level of granularity specified. Failure to provide itemized pricing will result in commercial disqualification.
- Most Favoured Nation (MFN): Aether Networks requires a Most Favoured Nation clause in the resulting contract, guaranteeing that pricing offered to Aether Networks is no less favourable than pricing offered to any comparable customer of the vendor globally.

6.2 Pricing Response Table

Vendors MUST complete the 'Quantity' and 'Unit Cost (USD)' columns in the table below. All other fields are pre-populated by Aether Networks. Do NOT modify any pre-populated fields. Add additional rows as necessary to itemize any components of the proposed solution not covered by the pre-defined line items. The rationale for any added rows must be provided in the accompanying commercial narrative (Section 6.3).

Item Category	Item Description	Unit Type	Quantity	Unit Cost (USD)
Software License	Converged Charging System (CCS) – Base License	Per Subscriber / Per Month	*[Vendor to Fill]*	*[Vendor to Fill]*
Software License	Product Catalog Management Module – Base License	Per Subscriber / Per Month	*[Vendor to Fill]*	*[Vendor to Fill]*
Software License	Billing & Invoice Management Module – Base License	Per Subscriber / Per Month	*[Vendor to Fill]*	*[Vendor to Fill]*
Software License	OSS / Network Provisioning Module – Base License	Per Subscriber / Per Month	*[Vendor to Fill]*	*[Vendor to Fill]*
Software License	Customer Self-Service Portal (B2C + B2B) – Base License	Fixed / Annual	*[Vendor to Fill]*	*[Vendor to Fill]*
Software License	Data Lake Integration Adapter (Snowflake/Databricks) – Base License	Fixed / Annual	*[Vendor to Fill]*	*[Vendor to Fill]*

Item Category	Item Description	Unit Type	Quantity	Unit Cost (USD)
Professional Services	Program Management & Governance (Project Management Office)	Per Day	*[Vendor to Fill]*	*[Vendor to Fill]*
Professional Services	Solution Architecture & Design Phase	Fixed	*[Vendor to Fill]*	*[Vendor to Fill]*
Professional Services	Development, Integration & Customization Services	Per Story Point	*[Vendor to Fill]*	*[Vendor to Fill]*
Professional Services	System Integration Testing (SIT) Services	Fixed	*[Vendor to Fill]*	*[Vendor to Fill]*
Professional Services	User Acceptance Testing (UAT) Support Services	Fixed	*[Vendor to Fill]*	*[Vendor to Fill]*
Professional Services	Subscriber Data Migration (Legacy to Target)	Per Million Subscribers	*[Vendor to Fill]*	*[Vendor to Fill]*
Infrastructure	Cloud Infrastructure (AWS/Azure/GCP) – Year 1 Estimated	Fixed / Annual	*[Vendor to Fill]*	*[Vendor to Fill]*
Infrastructure	On-Premise Bare Metal Server Rack Configuration (if applicable)	Per Unit	*[Vendor to Fill]*	*[Vendor to Fill]*
Training	Technical Training – Platform Administration (per cohort of 10)	Per Cohort	*[Vendor to Fill]*	*[Vendor to Fill]*
Training	Operational Training – NOC/SOC Runbook Certification	Per Cohort	*[Vendor to Fill]*	*[Vendor to Fill]*
Support & Maintenance	Standard Support (Business Hours, 12x5) – Annual	Fixed / Annual	*[Vendor to Fill]*	*[Vendor to Fill]*
Support & Maintenance	Premium Support (24x7x365, 4-hour SLA Response) – Annual	Fixed / Annual	*[Vendor to Fill]*	*[Vendor to Fill]*
Support & Maintenance	Dedicated Support Engineer (DSE) – Annual Retainer	Fixed / Annual	*[Vendor to Fill]*	*[Vendor to Fill]*

NOTE: *'Per Subscriber / Per Month' pricing must be based on the contractually committed subscriber volume of 45,000,000 active subscribers. Volume discount tiers for subscriber counts of 50M, 60M, and 75M must be provided in the commercial narrative.*

6.3 Commercial Narrative Requirement

In addition to completing the Pricing Response Table, vendors MUST provide a written commercial narrative (maximum 4 pages) addressing:

- Detailed breakdown of Total Cost of Ownership (TCO) over a 5-year horizon, segmented by Year 1 (implementation), Years 2-3 (stabilisation), and Years 4-5 (steady-state operations).
- Volume discount tiers and commercial incentives for subscriber growth milestones.
- Commercial treatment for optional modules (TR-013, OP-007, OP-012).
- Payment milestones linked to programme delivery milestones (go-live, data migration completion, decommission completion).

6.4 SLA Penalty and Service Credit Schedule

The following SLA penalty framework will be incorporated verbatim into the Master Services Agreement (MSA) resulting from this procurement. Vendor proposals must explicitly acknowledge acceptance of this framework. Proposals seeking to materially modify these terms will be evaluated negatively on the commercial scoring dimension.

- Tier-1 Outage (Complete loss of CCS charging capability for >10% of subscriber base): 5% service credit applied to the total invoice value for the affected calendar month for each continuous or cumulative period of 15 minutes or part thereof.
- Tier-2 Degradation (Charging latency exceeding 200ms p99 for >30 minutes): 2% service credit applied to the total invoice value for the affected calendar month.
- Tier-3 Non-Critical Incident (Any individual component failure not impacting live charging, SLA breach notification delay exceeding 30 minutes): 0.5% service credit applied to the total invoice value for the affected calendar month.
- SLA credit accumulation is capped at 20% of the total monthly invoice value per calendar month. Accumulated credits that exceed the cap carry over to subsequent months.
- Repeated Tier-1 incidents (3 or more within any rolling 90-day period) constitute a material breach entitling Aether Networks to terminate the agreement for cause with 30 days' written notice.

7. Vendor Qualifications and Mandatory Pre-Qualification Criteria

7.1 Mandatory Pre-Qualification Criteria

The following criteria constitute mandatory minimum thresholds for participation in this procurement. Vendors who do not meet ALL of the following criteria are ineligible to submit a proposal and will be administratively disqualified. Evidence for each criterion must be provided in the form specified below:

- Annual Revenue: Vendor's consolidated annual revenue must have exceeded USD 500,000,000 (Five Hundred Million United States Dollars) in each of the last three (3) completed fiscal years. Evidence: Provide audited annual financial statements for FY2022, FY2023, and FY2024.
- Comparable Global Deployments: Vendor must have achieved go-live for a minimum of three (3) comparable BSS/OSS transformation programmes globally within the last four (4) years (i.e., on or after 01 January 2021). For the purposes of this criterion, 'comparable' is defined as a cloud-native CCS deployment supporting a minimum of 20 million subscribers with 3GPP Release 15 or later compliance. Evidence: Complete the Reference Matrix in Section 7.2.
- Dedicated 5G BSS Practice: Vendor must maintain a dedicated business unit or practice with a minimum of 200 FTE professionals focused exclusively on 5G BSS/OSS solution delivery. Evidence: Provide an organizational chart and headcount breakdown by role and geography.
- European Operations: Vendor must maintain at least one (1) wholly owned legal entity registered within the European Union, with a minimum of 50 FTE in-region support capability. Evidence: Provide legal entity registration certificate and staffing declaration.
- Absence of Material Sanctions: Vendor, its subsidiaries, and its key subcontractors (>25% of delivery scope) must not be subject to any material economic sanction, debarment from public procurement, or regulatory enforcement action in any EU Member State. Evidence: Self-certification by authorized signatory.

7.2 Reference Matrix

Vendors MUST complete all fields in the following Reference Matrix for a minimum of three (3) qualifying reference deployments. Aether Networks reserves the right to contact all referenced clients directly to verify the information provided. Submission of false or materially misleading reference information will result in immediate disqualification and may be reported to applicable regulatory authorities.

Client Name	Region	Subscribers Migrated	Go-Live Date	Outcome Metrics
[Vendor to Fill]	*[Vendor to Fill]*	*[Vendor to Fill]*	*[Vendor to Fill]*	*[Vendor to Fill]*
[Vendor to Fill]	*[Vendor to Fill]*	*[Vendor to Fill]*	*[Vendor to Fill]*	*[Vendor to Fill]*
[Vendor to Fill]	*[Vendor to Fill]*	*[Vendor to Fill]*	*[Vendor to Fill]*	*[Vendor to Fill]*

NOTE: *Aether Networks will seek a client reference call with each organization listed. Vendors are advised to pre-notify their reference clients of this requirement prior to proposal submission. References from internal group companies or subsidiaries of the vendor are not eligible.*

7.3 Key Personnel

Vendors must nominate the following key personnel for this programme in their proposal. Curricula vitae for each nominated individual must be provided as Appendix D. Nominated individuals must remain committed to this programme through the go-live milestone. Any substitution of key personnel requires prior written approval from Aether Networks' Programme Director.

- Programme Director: Senior programme leadership responsible for overall delivery governance, executive escalation, and contractual accountability. Minimum 15 years' experience in BSS/OSS transformation programmes; at least 3 as Programme Director.
- Chief Solutions Architect: Responsible for end-to-end technical architecture design, compliance verification, and integration governance. Must hold TM Forum Frameworx certification and demonstrable 3GPP expertise.
- Head of Delivery: Responsible for day-to-day delivery management, sprint planning, and milestone tracking. Must hold PMP or PRINCE2 Practitioner certification.
- Head of Data Migration: Responsible for all data extraction, transformation, quality validation, and load activities for the legacy migration. Must provide evidence of at least two prior migrations of 20M+ subscriber records.
- Head of Security: Responsible for security architecture, penetration testing coordination, and regulatory compliance. Must hold CISSP or CISM certification.

8. RFP Timelines and Submission Instructions

8.1 Programme Timeline

The following key dates govern this RFP process. All dates are binding unless Aether Networks issues a formal amendment via the official procurement portal. Vendors must monitor the procurement portal regularly for any published amendments. Aether Networks shall not be liable for any loss or disadvantage suffered by a vendor due to failure to monitor published amendments.

Milestone	Target Date	Notes
RFP Release & Publication	15 July 2025	Aether Networks Procurement Portal
Vendor Registration Deadline	25 July 2025	Via Procurement Portal only
Vendor Q&A Submission Deadline	08 August 2025	Email to rfp-queries@aethernetworks.com
Aether Networks Q&A Response Publication	22 August 2025	Published to all registered vendors simultaneously
Mandatory Vendor Briefing Session (Virtual)	29 August 2025	Microsoft Teams – Invitation issued to registered vendors
Final Proposal Submission Deadline	26 September 2025, 17:00 CET	Via Procurement Portal (late submissions disqualified)
Vendor Shortlisting & Notification	17 October 2025	Shortlisted vendors notified via secure email
Vendor Demonstrations / Proof of Concept	03–14 November 2025	Aether Networks HQ, Amsterdam, Netherlands
Best and Final Offer (BAFO) Submission	28 November 2025	Via Procurement Portal
Contract Award Notification	19 December 2025	Formal written notification
Programme Kick-Off (Target)	05 January 2026	Aether Networks HQ, Amsterdam, Netherlands

NOTE: *All proposal submissions must be received via the Aether Networks official procurement portal (https://procurement.aethernetworks.com/rfp-AN-PROC-2025-0042) no later than 17:00 CET on 26 September 2025. Proposals submitted by email, courier, or any other channel will be rejected without evaluation, regardless of the reason for non-portal submission.*

8.2 Q&A Process

All vendor queries relating to this RFP must be submitted exclusively via the procurement portal's Q&A module by the Q&A Submission Deadline of 08 August 2025. The following rules govern the Q&A process:

- Queries submitted after the deadline will not be answered and will not form grounds for any post-submission clarification request.
- Queries must be submitted in English. Queries in other languages will not be translated or answered.
- Questions seeking legal or commercial advice, or questions seeking information that would provide the querying vendor with a competitive advantage over other vendors, will not be answered.

- Aether Networks' compiled responses to all valid queries will be published simultaneously to all registered vendors on 22 August 2025. Individual responses to specific vendors are not provided.
- Responses published via the Q&A process form part of this RFP and must be treated as binding amendments to the specification.
- Direct communication with Aether Networks personnel other than via the procurement portal Q&A module is strictly prohibited and may result in disqualification.

8.3 Proposal Structure and Format Requirements

Proposals must be submitted in strict compliance with the following structural and format requirements. Non-conforming proposals will be returned without evaluation:

- Format: PDF/A format (ISO 19005 compliant) for all submission documents. Microsoft Word or other editable source formats are not acceptable as primary submission documents.
- Language: English (United Kingdom spelling conventions). All technical specifications, SLA commitments, and commercial terms must be in English.
- Structure: Proposals must follow the identical section numbering as this RFP document. Each RFP section must be addressed in the corresponding proposal section. Reordering of sections is not permitted.
- Table Completion: Requirement tables (Sections 3 and 4) must be reproduced in their entirety in the proposal with Vendor Response and Vendor Remarks / Evidence columns completed. Requirement IDs must not be altered, re-numbered, or re-sequenced. Vendors must not modify pre-populated columns.
- Page Limit: The main proposal body (Sections 1–8) must not exceed 150 pages (A4, minimum 11pt Arial, 25mm margins). Appendices are not subject to a page limit.
- Appendix Structure: Appendix A (Vendor Financials), Appendix B (Security Certifications — see Section 5.3), Appendix C (TM Forum SID Mapping Document), Appendix D (Key Personnel CVs), Appendix E (Sample Contract/MSA and SLA Schedule).

8.4 Evaluation Methodology

Proposals will be evaluated using a weighted scoring methodology. The evaluation will be conducted in two stages:

- Stage 1 — Administrative and Pre-Qualification Review: Verification of mandatory pre-qualification criteria (Section 7.1). Pass/Fail. Proposals failing Stage 1 are eliminated without scoring.
- Stage 2 — Technical, Operational, and Commercial Evaluation: Scored evaluation across four dimensions: Technical Compliance (40% weight), Operational Excellence (20% weight), Security and Compliance (20% weight), and Commercial Competitiveness (20% weight).

Vendors shortlisted following Stage 2 scoring will be invited to deliver a live demonstration and proof of concept (PoC) at Aether Networks' headquarters in Amsterdam between 03–14 November 2025. The PoC scenario will be issued to shortlisted vendors no later than 24 October 2025. The PoC outcome will be weighted at 25% of the Stage 2 final score.

8.5 Contact Information

The sole authorised point of contact for all matters relating to this RFP is:

Group Procurement & Vendor Management

Aether Networks S.A.

Keizersgracht 520, 1017 EK Amsterdam, Netherlands

Procurement Portal: https://procurement.aethernetworks.com/rfp-AN-PROC-2025-0042

RFP Query Email: rfp-queries@aethernetworks.com (for portal access issues only)

NOTE: *Direct contact with any Aether Networks employee, director, or advisor outside of the authorised procurement portal channel is strictly prohibited during the RFP process and will result in the vendor's immediate and irrevocable disqualification.*

Appendix A — Vendor Financial Statements

[Vendor to attach audited annual financial statements for FY2022, FY2023, and FY2024 in this appendix. Financial statements must be prepared in accordance with IFRS or US GAAP and certified by an independent external auditor.]

Appendix B — Security Certifications

VENDOR INSTRUCTION: Attach all security certifications (ISO/IEC 27001:2022, PCI-DSS Level 1 AoC/RoC, SOC 2 Type II Report, and any additional relevant certifications) as PDF documents in this appendix. Do NOT embed certificate images or logos in the main proposal text. Each certification document must be clearly labeled with the certification standard, issuing body, certificate reference number, and validity dates.

Appendix C — TM Forum SID Mapping Document

[Vendor to provide a complete TM Forum Shared Information Data (SID) model mapping document (Release 22.0 or later) in this appendix, as required by Requirement TR-004. The document must demonstrate entity-by-entity mapping of the proposed platform's data model to the SID model.]

Appendix D — Key Personnel Curricula Vitae

[Vendor to provide Curricula Vitae for all Key Personnel nominated in Section 7.3. Each CV must not exceed 4 pages and must clearly evidence the qualifications, certifications, and reference experience stated in the proposal.]

Appendix E — Draft Master Services Agreement and SLA Schedule

[Vendor to provide a draft Master Services Agreement (MSA) and SLA Schedule based on the commercial framework specified in Section 6. Any proposed deviations from the SLA penalty framework in Section 6.4 must be explicitly highlighted and commercially justified.]

— END OF REQUEST FOR PROPOSAL DOCUMENT —

RFP Reference: AN-PROC-2025-0042 | Issuer: Aether Networks S.A. | Issue Date: 15 July 2025

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